

hence you have to make use of their resources,” explains Ellur. Naik, on the same note, needs to coordinate with the editorial team of the magazine he works on and hence is required to be at the client’s workstation. But Peringatt, being a programmer, can work from his home. His typical hours are from 11 am to 6 pm and then again from 11 pm to 3 am. “The most productive hours are during the night with absolutely no disturbance. Also, the Net is quite fast then,” he explains. But he generally prefers to “work till I drop, as I’m working for myself. It is very important that I finish work as soon as possible, so that I can move on to other interesting stuff”. Naik has a better work discipline. His work rotates around the other people in a given team and hence it isn’t completely at his convenience, though he can choose a particular project depending on his personal ability to handle it.

Show me the money

The crucial concern any individual set-



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complains that the site no longer offers the opportunities it initially did. Some unpleasant experiences by a few users prompted them to quit, but there are others who continue to be influenced by the concept.

Many of these sites operate worldwide, but the vendors handle currency conversion and the user is paid in the local currency. Most of them require you to pay a registration fee as deposit, which is refunded once the job is done. This fee is a precautionary measure to assure delivery on the scheduled date. In case you do not submit work at the designated time, the compensation would be reduced. This is where you need to be cautious as most of these services have a ‘do so at your own risk’ clause.

ting out on his own faces is that of money. After all, money is the reason most of us are in it. A regular job ensures a salary deposit in the bank at the end of the month. With freelancing, the work-to-pay ratio is always negotiable and never assured. How one discusses the pay packet again depends upon the nature of the work: Naik prefers to be paid by the day as it works very well with his work scenario since he is required to work from the client’s site for unpredictable hours, with focus more on the quantity of work rather than the quality. For Ellur, charging depends upon the project specifications and the customer comfort. “In cases where the customer himself is not clear about his requirements, it is advisable to charge by the hour where the specifications are frozen on a daily basis. When the customer is clear about the output, you can charge a lump sum,” says Ellur.

Peringatt, on the other hand, charges for the work put in and not the hours spent working, “so I don’t have to keep reporting to the client on how much work was done in a day, as I may be working on other parallel projects.” He continues, “Sometimes, charging by the hour is not justified. If the developer is skilled and has experience, it will take him much less time to finish the project compared to an inexperienced developer who would take months to research. An umbrella amount takes care of all these factors. The client is informed of a date when I will be able to present the demo or the deliverables and that date is adhered to.”

So how much can you hope to make on your own? And is this payment assured? Peringatt has had many distasteful experiences in this regard—“Getting money out of the client is a big headache. The money invariably gets delayed for some reason or another.” But Ellur begs to differ—he maintains that clients pay, at even a premium, provided that you deliver quality on time. A novice freelancer can hope to earn between Rs 10,000 to Rs 15,000 in any field, depending on the kind of contacts he or she has and the quality of the work. A seasoned IT consultant, in the opinion of Ellur, can make anything from Rs 30,000 to Rs 1,00,000 a month. A layout artist can make around Rs 7,000 throughout



Sailesh Peringatt
SOFTWARE PROGRAMMER

I am my own master; I only do things that interest or challenge me

the year and up to Rs 15,000 during the end of the year and festivals when magazines get out their special editions.

Bag of tricks

What you need to work on your own, besides a PC with all the peripherals of your trade, is a good database of contacts and people who will give you work. If you’ve already been working for a while, people are already familiar with your work and the trust hurdle is bypassed. Once the ball is set rolling, each project well delivered will ensure future work, as work relations with freelancers are based on trust. In the words of Ellur, “Being a freelancer, if you have five satisfied customers, then you are assured five more job offers for the future.” You can also tie up with a Web site online that trades services with companies that are on the lookout for them such as www.elance.com and www.freeagent.com. These sites are meeting points for those who are seeking specific professional services and those who can provide them (see box, ‘The Website Story’).

The availability of projects, like in any other profession, depends on the overall economic scenario and your own skill sets. The key is to constantly reinvent yourself and keep abreast of the skills and technologies in your field. Along with that, you need to cultivate a firm discipline and mark out your work hours. Always understand the nature of the project to its last detail so that there are no misunderstandings that could wash away hours of your work. With that, also calculate a rupee per work unit ratio that you can justify to your client—you don’t want to come across as exorbitantly priced, nor should you sell yourself short in anyway. Once you have these few things in place, all you need to do is work hard and the money will keep streaming in. 

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